Conventional analyses of the BJP's gender politics often misses the acute focus it places on women and how it managed to turn its traditional gender disadvantage around, especially in the Hindi heartland. India has long been among the eighty-odd countries counted by the International Monetary Fund (IMF) that practise gender budgeting. It started under Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in 2005-06 when the Union government began to apply a gender lens to government expenditures in order to prioritise gender-specific outcomes and tackle stark gender inequalities. According to a data analysis of the gendered sections of successive Union government budgets—which include schemes specifically targeted at women (such as Beti Bachao Beti Padhao) and those where women are also beneficiaries (like Mid-Day Meal initiatives)—this averaged to 5.04 per cent of the total government expenditure per year between 2005-06 and 2013-14.

Under Modi, this average came down to 5 per cent between 2014-15 and 2020-21.[108] While financial expenditures for gender-based outcomes generally fell or stagnated after hitting a high point of 5.9 per cent in the middle of UPA-2, the BJP focused on two things: a much greater political focus on how many women became beneficiaries of its general developmental schemes and more targeted cohesion and messaging around women-only schemes. A case in point is how, on Women's Day in 2020, the finance ministry pushed out a press release listing six general financial schemes where women had turned out to be the primary beneficiaries.[109] A great deal has been said of the Modi government's focus on the women-centric Ujjwala scheme—which provides LPG cylinders and a direct-cash transfer to women below the poverty line—but the political focus has been just as much on giving women a bigger share of the wider financial schemes.

On more conventional women-centric programmes, it is important to break down what Modi means when he talks of supporting women from the cradle to their death. In his personal public outreach, he divides this into four milestones. The first milestone is birth. For this, pregnant women not employed by the Union or any state government became entitled to direct-cash benefits from the state for the first time under PM Matru Vandana